



THE 'SECULAR' CPI(M) WILL NOW DEPEND ON THE CONSOLIDATION OF HINDU VOTES TO RETAIN POWER

DESPITE ITS LOUD CLAIMS OF CHAMPIONING secularism, most minority organisations see the Left Government as their worst enemy.

ity groups rallying behind the UDF, the LDF is now eyeing a possible Hindu backlash as its only hope in the coming elections to the local bodies this year followed by the Assembly elections next May.

Though the KC with its four seats is hardly in a position to rock the Government that has the support of 92 MLAs in the 140 seat-Assembly, its desertion comes as yet another jolt to the ruling Front. The Janata Dal(S) and Kerala Congress(S), with five and one seats respectively, have quit the LDF. The INL, although not a formal LDF constituent, has been an ally with one member in the House for the last four years. It too is now inching towards the other side. Besides these parties, three former CPI(M) MPs, A.P. Abdullakkutty, K.S. Manoj and K. Sivaraman, have crossed over to the UDF during this period. Abdullakkutty

and Manoj had charged the party with being anti-minority. The LDF has cried foul, saying Joseph was driven only by crass opportunism. "Joseph had never uttered a word against any of our policies while he was with us. He has crossed over thinking that the UDF is a greener pasture," lamented Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan.

The Government has now found that just before leaving the Cabinet, Joseph gave unauthorised sanction for public works estimated to be worth over Rs 40 crore, mostly in his own constituency, Thodupuzha. "None of these works will be cleared. An inquiry has been ordered on the clearances by Joseph," said Thomas Isaac, state finance minister. "Joseph's move is the agenda of certain anti-communist elements in the

Church. It is a naked transgression by a section of the clergy to meddle in politics," said Vijayan. The Congress had campaigned against Joseph's alleged involvement in some scams and he had to quit the Cabinet in 2007 after a woman passenger complained that she was sexually harassed by him on a Kingfisher flight from Chennai to Thiruvananthapuram. Joseph rejoined the Cabinet in 2009 after a court found him innocent.

Ironically, despite gaining an unwelcome ally, the UDF is riven with dissension and the CPI(M)-led LDF appears unperturbed by the increasing distancing of minorities. The reasons are two. First, it knows that it is impossible to roll back its steps to control the management of private professional colleges. Second, the LDF, with hardly anything to crow about, now hopes for a consolidation of secular votes or a Hindu backlash against the UDF. History may or may not repeat itself just yet, but 23 years on, Kerala is living with another of the great ironies. The CPI(M)'s best hope lies in the religious hunger for consolidation of the majority community. ■